

221-206 BCE

THE QIN DYNASTY

The Qin established a unified empire in 221 BCE, marking the end of the Warring States Period in China. Zheng, king of the Qin state, conquered the other six belligerent states and, as Emperor Qin Shi Huang, founded the Qin dynasty, the first Imperial Chinese dynasty.

Qin Shi Huang's success can be attributed to the strict disciplinarian regime he had established in Qin, which he then applied throughout the empire. Among his achievements was the standardization of currency, weights and measures, and writing systems; he also ordered several massive infrastructure projects, including the building of a northern wall which later formed the foundation of the Great Wall

of China, and a major network of roads that helped to encourage trade between China's distant regions. One of his most striking pursuits was a vanity project, the construction of a vast mausoleum, as big as a city, to house his own tomb, defended by an army of terracotta figures.

The Qin dynasty was regarded as tyrannical by many in the conquered states, and the regime came down hard on any dissenting voices. However, Qin Shi Huang and his advisors succeeded in unifying the country after centuries of conflict. The dynasty was not to last: in 206 BCE the second — and final — Qin emperor was overthrown, and the dynasty was brought to an end.



KEY MOMENTS

221 BCE Qin Shi Huang takes power

The founder of the Qin dynasty, Qin Shi Huang (*left*), reigned as king from 247 to 221 BCE, and then proclaimed himself Emperor of a unified China after emerging triumphant over the Warring States. His wide-ranging reforms laid the foundations for subsequent Chinese dynasties to follow for more than 2,000 years. After his death his successor, Qin Ershi, was soon ousted by the Han dynasty.

221-210 BCE Imposition of Legalism

Emperor Qin Shi Huang set about establishing centralized control, ending the political and cultural diversity of the “Hundred Schools of Thought” associated with the Seven Warring States. With the help of his Imperial Chancellor Li Si, he imposed a strict authoritarian form of government known as Legalism, and a brutal purge of the classical scholars of the previous Zhou Dynasty. Books were burned and many scholars were buried alive (*left*).

